

Happily Mauried

It's called Mauri, and no Hindu wedding in Bihar is complete without it. The twist in the tale is that this headgear is crafted in just one locality of Patna.

Uttar
Pradesh

BIHAR

PATNA

Orissa

West
Bengal



Krishna Murari Mishra

A MAURI CRAFTSMAN AT HIS TRADE IN PATNA

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Marriages may be made in heaven, but are rarely solemnised in this part of the world without the bridegroom wearing a traditional hand-embroidered headgear—called a Mauri. Surprisingly, just about anyone with a wedding happening in the family walks down to one narrow lane in Patna with more than a hundred shops dealing exclusively in the headgear. In fact, Mauri and the lives of the people trading in it are so inextricably intermingled that the locality is identified with the headgear's name: it's called Mauri Gali. The foot-high Mauri, woven around bamboo sticks, is a dazzling accessory that a Hindu bridegroom adorns for specific wedding rituals. For the rest of the ceremony, bridegrooms usually switch to more convenient Rajasthani headgear. Despite less than an hour of use and near zero utility afterwards, the Mauri remains indispensable. "In fact, more and more people are joining the trade, forcing us to cut prices," says craftsman Awadhesh Kumar Chandrawanshi.

Interestingly, unlike other professions where shrinking profit margins have made people move to greener

pastures, the traders of Mauri Gali have stayed put. One wedding season gives Mauri Gali business worth Rs 40 to 50 lakh, every shop selling more than a thousand Mauris at between Rs 30 and 750 each. This business is a huge hit with buyers not only from Bihar but also from West Bengal, Jharkhand and Uttar Pradesh.

Although all Mauris are beautiful, the more expensive ones are golden, decorated flamboyantly and embellished with beads, sequins, lace and sparkling paper. The shopkeepers' family members work tirelessly along with skilled craftsmen to create the Mauris—a fine art that has remained classical and distinctive over ages. Now, Mauri-makers have also started designing Rajasthani headgear from brocade, crepe, satin and chiffon in a range of hues as well as combinations of purple-cream and blue-brown. Selling these makes sense, as their sale is clubbed with that of the Mauri.

During the lean season, the artisans take to designing rakhis and crowns for goddesses. Mauri Gali stays alive all year round, combining tradition with improvisation. You couldn't ask for a more heady business. ■